Many years later, in 1582, the year of Akbar's triumphant return from Kabul and his first Nauroz, Abul Fazl does, in fact, write of Hamida asking Akbar to forgive one of his less-than-loyal Bengal nobles: the man was a close friend of the family and Hamida wanted him restored to favour.

Akbar agreed. And yet, while he wouldn't refuse his mother's wishes, there was no reason why the emperor shouldn't get his own way despite them. Three months after the chieftain was restored to favour, he was on his way home from court at around midnight when 'an armed troop fell upon him . . . and cut him in pieces'.[49] Despite 'much investigation and close inquiry', writes Abul Fazl, poker-faced, ' the affair was not cleared up.' Nothing came to light; except, of course, that yet another enemy of the emperor's had died.

Clearly, Akbar would not let his mother interfere in his government, any more than he would the Qaqshals. The curb on his harem's powers was not quite the same, however, as the taming of Akbar's warlords. Timurid women had long played active political roles: Babur describes his grandmother as his best adviser, and there is a painting that depicts his sister, Khanzada, sitting in council with Babur and his chiefs. Akbar, too, would accept advice and help from his female relatives – and learn Hindu rituals from his Rajput wives – but something was changing.

'He gives very great care and attention to the education of the princesses,' writes Father Monserrate, 'who are kept rigorously secluded from the sight of men.' Thus, the Fathers were made to stand by the Anup Talao when they arrived, so that Akbar's harem might observe them without being seen. The scene captures something of Akbar's increasingly ambiguous relationship with his women. His daughters were to be educated and prepared to engage in public life; and yet, they were to be kept hidden from it.

If Akbar was surprised, even distressed, by what he saw of Rajput women's exclusion from the world in which their men thrived, he was also influenced by what Harbans Mukhia calls 'the Rajputs' normative placement of high value of honour in their women's bodies, manifest in the performance of *sati* and *jauhar*'.[50] Mukhia notes that Babur's memoirs 'hardly ever' make reference to female 'chastity'; that Gulbadan's memoirs abound with unveiled princesses who 'rode horses, went on hunt (*shikar*), practised archery and went out on picnics'. Indeed, Babur's sister Khanzada